**Immanuel Dietrich**
Utrecht, Netherlands
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immanueld49@gmail.com
+49 1512 9081675
http://linkedin.com/in/immanuel-dietrich

**Rijkswaterstaat**
Griffioenlaan 2
3526 LA Utrecht

Beste lezer,

Met deze motivatiebrief wil ik graag solliciteren naar de positie van Adviseur chemische waterkwaliteit bij Rijkswaterstaat. De werkzaamheden en doelstellingen van deze functie spreken mij bijzonder aan. Hoewel ik inmiddels bijna twee jaar in Nederland (Utrecht) woon, ben ik de taal nog aan het leren en druk ik mijzelf makkelijker uit in het Engels:

## 1. Motivation

I am particularly interested in this position because it allows me to apply both my academic background and my practical experience to improve water quality. During my master's programme I specialised in PFAS removal from water, which showed me how complex and important the challenge of emerging contaminants is. My thesis strengthened both my technical knowledge and my interest in translating scientific findings into practical solutions.
What motivates me most is contributing to cleaner and safer surface water. While PFAS is one important issue, I am equally interested in addressing other chemical pollutants and preventing them from entering the water system in the first place. I enjoy working on complex problems that require both technical expertise and collaboration with different stakeholders, which is what this position offers.

## 2. Organisational Sensitivity

**Situation:** During my bachelor's thesis internship, I worked on a European Union-funded drinking water treatment project in Serbia. I was one of the few international team members and had to work closely with local utility employees, who operated in a different organisational and cultural environment.
**Task:** Besides carrying out my technical work, I needed to coordinate with local colleagues to ensure that the project progressed despite differences in working methods, priorities and communication styles.
**Action:** At first, cooperation was difficult. Some colleagues were reluctant to continue certain tasks and there were different expectations regarding responsibilities. At first, I insisted on my own approach, but at a later stage I understood that I had to understand their concerns, communicate respectfully and explain to them, why certain activities were necessary. I focused discussions on our shared objective instead of the differences between us.
**Result:** The cooperation improved significantly, allowing us to continue the project successfully and contribute to the commissioning of a functioning drinking water treatment plant for the local community.
**Reflection:** This experience taught me that organisational sensitivity is about recognising different interests and perspectives while keeping everyone focused on a common goal. I learned that listening and adapting my communication style are often just as important as technical expertise.

## 3. Content Knowledge

**Situation:** During my master's thesis, I investigated the potential of molecularly imprinted polymers (MIPs) for the removal of PFAS from contaminated water. PFAS are persistent pollutants that are difficult to remove with conventional treatment technologies and therefore present a significant challenge for water authorities.
**Task:** My objective was to evaluate the technological readiness of molecularly imprinted polymers for PFAS removal and assess whether they could become a viable treatment technology.
**Action:** I conducted a literature review and analysed experimental results from my own laboratory study. I compared the adsorption performance of MIPs with existing treatment technologies, evaluated their selectivity, regeneration potential, and scalability, and identified the technical and practical barriers that currently limit their implementation.
**Result:** My research resulted in a technological readiness assessment of molecularly imprinted polymers for PFAS removal, complemented by a barrier analysis that identified the main technical challenges preventing wider application.
**Reflection:** This project taught me that developing evidence-based advice requires more than technical knowledge. Research often presents unexpected challenges, requiring continuous adaptation of experimental plans and critical evaluation of new information. I learned to remain flexible, systematically assess available evidence, and translate scientific findings into practical conclusions that can support decision-making.

## 4. Analysing

**Situation:** During my master's thesis, I had to analyse a large amount of scientific literature together with experimental data on PFAS removal technologies.
**Task:** My challenge was to identify the most relevant information and draw reliable conclusions despite the large volume of available data.
**Action:** I first organised the information into logical categories. I then visualised the relationships between these categories using diagrams and tables, allowing me to compare studies systematically and identify patterns and inconsistencies - using flow charts, mind maps or excel tables. Throughout the process, I continuously checked whether each piece of information contributed to answering my research question.
**Result:** This structured approach enabled me to produce a clear overview of the available evidence and draw well-supported conclusions for my thesis.
**Reflection:** I learned that careful organisation and visualisation make complex information much easier to interpret. Rather than trying to process everything at once, I break complex problems into manageable parts and focus on the information that is most relevant for the objective.
Thank you for considering my application.

Kind regards,
**Immanuel Dietrich**